Sensory & Colour Word Banks

Concept

Use precise sensory details to help a reader imagine a scene. Select a few meaningful details instead of piling on adjectives.

Five senses

Sight, sound, touch, taste and smell create different routes into a scene.

Specific detail

Choose the detail that reveals setting, action or mood.

Colour + meaning

A colour word suggests shade and sometimes texture or association. Check the actual meaning before substituting.

Context matters

The supplied banks include nouns, adjectives and verbs. They are descriptive options, not universal synonyms.

Example 1 | original model

Revise: The kitchen was nice.

Solution / why it works

1. Choose the intended mood: warm and welcoming.
2. Revision: Amber light spread across the table, and the scent of toasted bread drifted from the oven.
3. Sight and smell support the mood without naming every sense.

Sensory & Colour Word Banks

Word bank | Sound

blaring	lilting	scream
boisterous	low	screech
booming	mellow	shrill
brassy	mellifluous	silent
buzz	melodic	slam
caterwaul	monotonous	snap
chime	muffled	squawk
clink	musical	squeak
crackle	muted	squeal
crunch	noiseless	staccato
deafening	noisy	thump
dulcet	patter	thunderous
earsplitting	peep	tinkle
explosive	piercing	unspoken
grinding	popping	wail
gurgle	pulsating	wheezing
hiss	raucous	whine
honking	resounding	whispered
howling	rhythmic	whistle
hum	riotous	yelp
hushed	roaring	yowl
jingle	rumbling	

Sensory & Colour Word Banks

Word bank | Sight

ancient	drab	indistinct
angular	dramatic	insipid
animated	elegant	irregular
arrogant	energetic	irresistible
attractive	exhausted	jammed
awkward	exotic	lavish
beefy	faded	leafy
bleary	feathery	lively
blotched	feeble	loose
blurry	flashy	massive
bold	flat	miniature
bright	flimsy	misty
brilliant	fluffy	muddled
broken	flush	muddy
bruised	formal	murky
bulky	frail	muscular
chaotic	frightened	opulent
cheap	frilled	orderly
cluttered	gaudy	painted
colored	glassy	peaceful
colorless	glistening	placid
congested	gloomy	pristine
crinkled	glossy	radiant
curved	glowing	ramshackle
dazzling	grassy	regal
delicate	handsome	rigid
dim	hazy	robust
dingy	hefty	ruffled

Sensory & Colour Word Banks

Word bank | Sight (continued)

shabby
shadowy
shapely
sheer
shimmering
shiny
sickly
slender
smudged
sparkling
sparkly
speckled
spongy
spotted
sprinkled
stout
streaked
stretched
striped
sturdy
sunny
supple
swarming
swollen
tangled
tantalizing
tidy
timid
tinted
tranquil
vibrant
vivid
wavy
waxy
weightless
weighty
wild
wiry
worn
wrecked
wrinkled

Word bank | Touch

abrasive
arid
balmy
blistering
boiling
breezy
bristly
bumpy
burning
chafing
chilly
clammy
coarse
cool
crisp
cushioned
damp
dehydrated
dense
dried
dull
dusty
elastic
feathery
fleshy
fluffy
fragile
freezing
fresh
frosty
furry
fuzzy
gluey
greasy
gritty
hairy

Sensory & Colour Word Banks

Word bank | Touch (continued)

heavy
icy
itchy
jagged
leathery
lukewarm
moist
mushy
oily
plastic
prickly
rubbery
sandy
satiny
scalding
scorching
searing
sharp
silky
sizzling
slight
slimy
slippery
spiky
spongy
steamy
sticky
stocky
tender
tepid
thick
tough
velvety
waxy

Word bank | Taste

acidic
bitter
bittersweet
bland
briny
burnt
buttery
citrusy
creamy
crisp
fatty
fiery
fishy
fresh
fruity
full-bodied
gristly
greasy
hearty
herbal
insipid
juicy
leathery
lemony
metallic
mild
nasty
nutty
oily
peppery
piquant
pungent
rancid
raw
refreshing
rich
robust
rotten
salty
savory
sharp
smoky

Sensory & Colour Word Banks

Word bank | Taste (continued)

sour
spicy
stale
stinging
sugared
sugary
sweet
syrupy
tangy
tart
toasty
understated
unpalatable
vinegary
woody
yeasty
zesty

Word bank | Smell

acrid
aromatic
balmy
bouquet
briny
burnt
cedar
clean
coppery
delicate
earthy
faint
fetid
fishy
floral
flowery
foul
fragrant
fresh
fruity
funky
gamy
gaseous
heady
intoxicating
malodorous
medicinal
methane
mild
minty
moldy
musty
odorless
odorous
off
offensive
overpowering
perfumed
piney
potent
pungent
putrid
putrescent
rancid
rank
reeking
repugnant
ripe
robust
rosy
rotten
savory
scented
sharp
skunky
smelly
smoky
sour
spoiled
stagnant

Sensory & Colour Word Banks

Word bank | Smell (continued)

stale
stench
stinky
stuffy
sulphuric
sweet
tempting
unsavory
unscented
woody

Word bank | Red

blood
bloodshot
blush
burgundy
cardinal
carmine
cherry
coral
crimson
damask
garnet
pink
rose
ruby
ruddy
salmon
sanguine
scarlet
tomato

Word bank | Orange

amber
apricot
bourbon
carnelian
copper
coral
dayglo
fire
gold
mango
marigold
papaya
peach
persimmon
pumpkin
rust
tangerine
tawny
titian

Sensory & Colour Word Banks

Word bank | Yellow

blond
buff
butterscotch
canary
champagne
cream
dandelion
eggshell
gold
golden
goldenrod
honey
lemon
maize
mustard
ocher
saffron
straw
topaz

Word bank | Green

apple
army
avocado
chartreuse
emerald
fern
forest
holly
jade
kelly
leaf
lime
mint
olive
pine
reseda
sea foam

Word bank | Blue

aqua
aquamarine
azure
baby
bice
blueberry
cerulean
cobalt
cyan
heather
ice
indigo
midnight
navy
robin's egg
royal
sapphire
teal
turquoise

Sensory & Colour Word Banks

Word bank | Purple

amethyst
aubergine
blackberry
brandywine
byzantium
cerise
eggplant
fuchsia
grape
heliotrope
iris
lavender
lilac
magenta
maroon
mauve
orchid
periwinkle
plum
raisin
violet
wisteria

Word bank | Brown

auburn
beige
bronze
brunette
burnt sienna
caramel
chestnut
chocolate
cinnamon
cocoa
coffee
drab
fawn
ginger
hazel
khaki
mahogany
nut
sepia
tawny
toast
umber

Word bank | White

alabaster
antique
arctic
ashen
birch
blanched
bloodless
chalky
cotton
cream
fair
frosted
ghostly
ivory
lace
pale
pallid
pasty
pearl
pearly
sickly

Sensory & Colour Word Banks

Word bank | White (continued)

snowy

Word bank | Black

abyss
blackout
carbon
chalkboard
charcoal
coal
dark
darkness
ebony
jet
licorice
mica
midnight
molasses
obsidian
onyx
pitch
raven
sable
shadow
slate
sooty

Word bank | Other colours & patterns

achromatic
buff
checkered
freckled
heather
hounds-tooth
iridescent
matte
mottled
natural
nude
opaque
polka-dotted
psychedelic
rainbow
silver
sparkly
speckled
spotted
stained
striped
transparent

Sensory & Colour Word Banks

Practice | your turn

1. Describe a rainy bus stop in two sentences using sound and touch.

2. Describe the same room twice: once welcoming, once unsettling. Change three details.

3. Choose an unfamiliar colour word from the bank. Check its meaning and use it accurately.

Sensory & Colour Word Banks

Sample answers | check after trying

Writing tasks can have more than one strong answer. Use these models and checks to review your work.

1

Possible detail: Rain tapped the shelter roof; cold water seeped through my sleeve.

2

Welcoming: warm light, soft cushions, fresh bread. Unsettling: dim light, clammy fabric, stale air.

3

Check both the shade and the grammar. "An azure sky" works; colour names are not interchangeable.

Source & editing note

Sensory and Color Synonyms Words List to enhance writing.pdf | 3 supplied pages.

Source credited to Simply Novel in the supplied PDF. Concepts reorganized and condensed; repeated templates consolidated. Examples, practice and sample answers here are original additions, not copied student work.

The unclear source entry "velve" was omitted from the taste bank. Word categories reflect the supplied list; choose according to context.